

Seriously, Now!

Perhaps the most awaited sequel of this year, *Serious Sam 2* is finally here. We reviewed the demo, which is provided with this magazine's CD

To begin with, the demo seemed really small in terms of file size! Just about 250 MB for a proper FPS game demo is sort of odd these days. I crossed my fingers and installed anyway.

The test bed was an AMD Athlon 64 3200+ (939 pin), 1 GB DDR 400 MHz Transcend RAM, MSI RS480 MII motherboard, 80 GB SATA Seagate Barracuda hard drive, and a 256 MB 6600 GT PCIe graphics card. The intro cut scene was funny, as usual, and then the killing began!

Before I tell you more, you should know that *Serious Sam* has always been anything but serious! Don't expect realism and don't think that it's anything like *HalfLife 2*, *DOOM 3* or *F.E.A.R.* This game is, and always has been, a funny FPS with stupid-looking monsters, weird weapons and great 3D backgrounds!

The settings interface is clean and easy to navigate. The game automatically sets the ideal graphics settings for your configuration—of course, I changed it all to the highest settings, not really giving a damn if it framed, so long as it was beautiful!

I entered the game and these weird-looking things shot green blobs at Sam. Of course, Sam promptly picked up weapons and ammo and began the carnage. Soon after, he picked up a parrot, (yes, a parrot that carries a bomb). Eager to use this cool weapon, Sam went looking for more monsters! The search didn't last long—as soon as he approached some enemies, stupidly standing around doing absolutely nothing, the game froze.

The sound looped, the video stayed still: the game had just hung! I pressed [Esc], hoping I wouldn't have to do a cold reboot. It worked! The game menu popped up after 10 seconds, and I clicked 'Resume Game', hoping the bug would just go away—but it didn't. I quit the game and immediately went online, searching for some feedback from others. I found that many people were facing the same problem. Then I saw a patch for the demo. Oh well!

Anyway, long story short, even the patch didn't work, and the game kept hanging intermittently.

I still played it anyway, exiting after every hang, and then restarting and continuing from where I had left off. Yes, the game was fun enough for me to bear with such nonsense—the other *Digit* team members in my bay had to put up with sudden screams of anguish (and expletives), but I couldn't care less—after all, this was *Serious Sam 2*!

So how is the game?

With advanced features such as High Dynamic Range (HDR) rendering, the Serious engine is great for this game. CroTeam, the Croatian developers of the game and the engine, have done a decent job with everything. Even the AI is not completely stupid, though nowhere near intelligent. *Serious Sam* has always been about hordes of easy-to-kill enemies attacking at once, not about a few smart enemies that are hard to kill!

Overall, the enemy bosses seem too easy to kill... the monsters have weird flat textures, which is only funny for a while, after which it starts to look shabby! There's already a *Serious Sam 2 Demo #2* out, which fixes the bugs of the first demo and adds a level to shut up the dissenting fans—in our humble opinion, you're better off downloading the second demo. We'll provide it on our December DVD.

If you just cannot wait, like me, install this demo and give it a try. If you're a *Serious Sam* fan like I am, it will be worth it—well, barely worth it. If you're not a fan, wait till we provide the second demo, because this one just does not do justice! ☒

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Like in the first part, you're still always attacked by hordes of baddies



The scenery is great but the enemy bosses look a little stupid—but then again, this is *Serious Sam*. At least the audio is great, and will keep you entertained!



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